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Turning runners into cyclists

More and more runners are walking into our stores wanting to start cycling. They are the best new customers a bike shop can get. This brief covers why cycling helps a runner, what worries them, how to answer it, and why they are worth looking after.

1. Why cycling is good for a runner

- **Fitness without the pounding.** Every running step lands with two to three times body weight. Cycling trains the same heart and lungs with almost no impact. A runner can add training hours without adding injury risk.
- **Recovery.** An easy spin the day after a long run moves blood through tired legs without stressing them.
- **Training through injury.** Shin pain, plantar fasciitis, a sore knee: many runners who cannot run can still ride, once their doctor or physio agrees. The bike keeps fitness while the injury heals.
- **Stronger legs for hills.** Cycling loads the quads and glutes, which helps on climbs and late in a race.
- **Leg speed.** Pedalling at 85 to 95 rpm trains quick, light leg turnover.
- **Variety.** A new skill and new routes keep a tired runner motivated.
- **A door to new events.** Duathlon first, then triathlon.

Be honest about the limit: cycling does not replace running. Running fitness needs running. The bike replaces the easy and recovery runs, not the key sessions.

2. Why runners are our next big customers

- **They already have the engine.** Fitness and discipline are in place. They will ride regularly, so they will use what they buy.
- **They already spend on sport.** Shoes replaced every 600 to 800 km, a GPS watch, nutrition, race entries. A bike is a bigger step of the same habit.
- **They train for events.** A date on the calendar means a reason to buy, and to come back.
- **They come in groups.** Running clubs talk. One happy convert brings five more.
- **They follow a path.** Runner, then cyclist, then duathlete, then triathlete. Each step is another purchase: first bike, shoes and pedals, indoor trainer, a second bike, wheels, a bike bag for race travel.
- **They need service.** A rider who trains all year comes into the workshop all year.

The first bike is not the sale. It is the start of a customer who may buy from us for ten years.

3. The doubts they bring, and the answers

THEY SAY	WHAT IS BEHIND IT	WHAT TO SAY AND DO

"Won't cycling make my legs heavy and slow?"	Fear of losing running speed	Easy riding does not build bulk. It adds aerobic fitness. Keep the key runs and ride on the easy days.
"I'm scared of traffic."	Safety	Early morning routes, group beginner rides, lights and a helmet. Or start on an indoor trainer.
"The saddle will hurt."	Comfort	Padded shorts, the right saddle and a proper fit. Discomfort in the first two weeks is normal and passes. Pain is a fit problem.
"It's too expensive."	Unsure of the value	Compare it with what they already spend on running in a year. Show a sensible first bike, not the dream bike.
"Which bike? I don't know anything."	Overwhelmed	Ask the goal, show two bikes, explain one difference.
"I don't have time for another sport."	Schedule	They are swapping two easy runs for two rides, not adding. A trainer makes 45 minutes at home count.
"What if I get a puncture?"	Fear of being stranded	Teach a tube change in the store, and sell the spare tube, levers and pump with the bike.
"Clip-in pedals scare me."	Fear of falling	Start on flat pedals. Move to clip-in pedals after a month or two, and practise on a trainer or grass first.

4. The real challenges once they start

- **Big engine, new muscles.** A runner's heart and lungs are far ahead of their cycling muscles and bike handling. They push big gears too hard, too soon. The usual result is knee pain.
- **Low cadence.** Runners tend to grind at 60 to 70 rpm. Coach them to spin an easy gear at 80 to 90 rpm.
- **Wrong saddle height.** Too low strains the front of the knee. Too high rocks the hips. This is why the fit comes before the first ride.
- **Heart rate confusion.** Heart rate on the bike runs lower than when running at the same effort, often by 5 to 10 beats. Running zones do not apply. Tell them not to chase their running numbers.
- **Bike handling.** Braking, cornering, riding in a group and looking behind are skills. Fitness does not supply them.
- **Neck, hands and back.** New positions take a few weeks to settle. Start with short rides.

5. How to start them properly

- **Weeks 1 to 4:** two rides a week of 45 to 60 minutes, easy, in place of easy or recovery runs.
- **Weeks 5 to 8:** one longer weekend ride of 90 minutes to two hours, plus one short ride.
- **Always:** easy gears, cadence 80 to 90, and no hard efforts for the first month.
- Their running watch already records rides. Add a handlebar mount or a bike computer so they can see it while riding.

6. Which bike

THE RUNNER'S GOAL	WHAT TO SHOW

Recovery and cross-training, short rides, nervous in traffic	A fitness hybrid
Long weekend rides, wants to join a cycling group, may race a duathlon or triathlon	An endurance road bike
Mostly weekday training, short of time, worried about traffic	Add an indoor smart trainer
Already entered a triathlon	An endurance road bike, with clip-on aero bars later

Do not sell a first-timer a TT bike or an aggressive race bike. If they stay in the sport, they will come back for it.

7. The conversation

- What do you run: distance, how many days a week, which events?
- Any injuries, now or recently?
- What do you want from cycling: recovery, fitness, or a duathlon or triathlon?
- Where and when would you ride?
- Which watch do you use?
- What is your budget, including helmet and kit?

Speak their language. Runners understand easy days, long days, zones, cadence and events. "This replaces your recovery run" lands better than any spec.

8. What goes with the bike

Helmet, padded shorts, front and rear lights, bottle and cage, pump, spare tube and tyre levers. Offer a bike fit and the ESP service plan at delivery. Tell them about beginner group rides, and call after two weeks to ask how the first rides went. That call is where a runner becomes a cyclist.

Remember these

- Cycling gives runners fitness without impact, recovery, and a way to train through injury. It does not replace running.
- Runners have the engine, the spending habit, events and a community. They follow a path to duathlon and triathlon.
- Answer the doubts: bulk, traffic, saddle, cost, time, punctures, clip-in pedals.
- Fit first. Easy gears at 80 to 90 rpm. Two easy rides a week in place of easy runs. Heart rate runs lower on the bike.
- Hybrid or endurance road bike first. Never a TT bike for a first-timer.